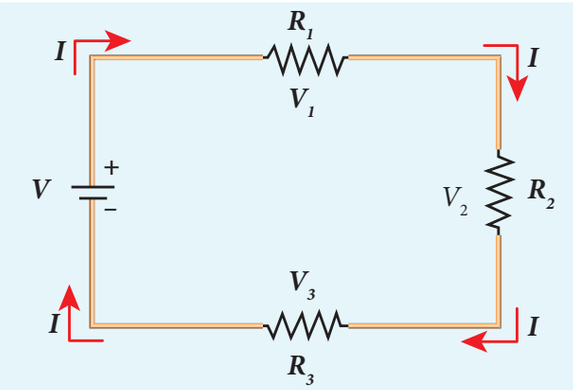
2.2.2 Resistors in series and parallel

An electric circuit may contain a number of resistors which can be connected in different ways. For each type of circuit, we can calculate the equivalent resistance produced by a group of individual resistors.

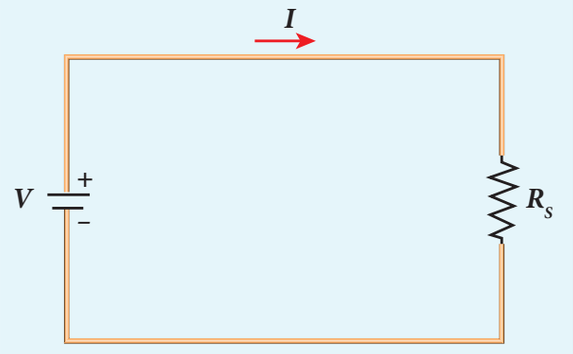
Resistors in series

When two or more resistors are connected end to end, they are said to be in series. The resistors could be simple resistors or bulbs or heating elements or other devices. Figure 2.9 (a) shows three resistors R_1, R_2 and R_3 connected in series.

The amount of charge passing through resistor R_1 must also pass through resistors R_2 and R_3 since the charges cannot accumulate anywhere in the circuit. Due to this reason, the current I passing through all the three resistors is the same. According to Ohm's law, if same current pass through different resistors of different values, then the potential difference across each resistor must be different. If V_1, V_2 and V_3 be the potential differences (voltage) across each of the resistors R_1, R_2 and R_3 respectively, then we can write $V_1 = IR_1$, $V_2 = IR_2$ and $V_3 = IR_3$. But the supply voltage V must be equal to the sum of voltages(potential differences) across each resistor.



(a) Three resistors in series



(b) Equivalent resistance (R_S) has the same current

Figure 2.9 Resistors in series

$$V = V_1 + V_2 + V_3 = IR_1 + IR_2 + IR_3 \quad (2.21)$$

$$V = I(R_1 + R_2 + R_3)$$

$$V = IR_S \quad (2.22)$$

where R_S is the equivalent resistance.

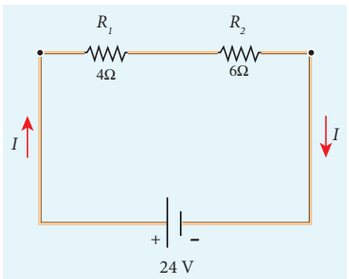
$$R_S = R_1 + R_2 + R_3 \quad (2.23)$$

When several resistors are connected in series, the total or equivalent resistance is the sum of the individual resistances as shown in the Figure 2.9 (b).

Note: The value of equivalent resistance in series connection will be greater than each individual resistance.

EXAMPLE 2.8

Calculate the equivalent resistance for the circuit which is connected to 24 V battery and also find the potential difference across each resistors in the circuit.



UNIT-2(XII-Physics_Vol-1).indd 90 14-02-2020 19:36:54